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Vermont Framework for K-8 Social Studies

Introduction

The Vermont Framework for K-8 Social Studies was developed by the Vermont Agency of Education (AOE) as a means to assist and support curriculum leaders as they write or revise curriculum for their districts. The framework relies heavily on what has been developed nationally (see acknowledgments), is based on the Vermont State Board of Education-adopted College, Career, and Civic Life (C3) Framework for State Standards, and encompasses a lens aligned to the work of the Ethnic Studies and Social Equity Standards Working Group.

Purpose

The framework provides connections for educators on how to incorporate themes and grade-appropriate topics, such as financial literacy, Holocaust education, media literacy, and civic values (see Guiding Principles for Effective History and Social Science Education, below). Connections to literacy were also considered in the framework, as data supports that providing students with background social studies knowledge improves literacy development, as "(s)ocial studies education can help improve stagnant literacy outcomes because social studies instruction can help build systematic knowledge and vocabulary in multiple domains that are broadly applicable and transferable to other topics (How Social Studies Improves Elementary Literacy)."

The identified Sample C3 Indicators within each grade-band are synthesized directly from Dimension 2 of the C3 standards; Dimensions 1, 3, and 4 can be woven into the instructional practice and resource selection and are also integral to the Inquiry Process. Along with the Sample Content Connections, the Sample C3 Indicators represent guidance on key concepts and skills to provide a more robust education in social studies. The samples help to support the implementation of the Rule Series 2000-Education Quality Standards, which emphasize that:

> Each school district shall enable students to engage annually in rigorous, relevant, and comprehensive learning opportunities that allow them to demonstrate proficiency in the content areas […] (d) Global citizenship, including the concepts of civics, economics, geography, world language and cultural studies, and history.

Contact: Martha Deiss, Curriculum & Instruction Division, at Martha.Deiss@vermont.gov

Finally, the framework recognizes the opportunity to create equitable social studies learning for Vermont students. The suggested scope and sequence, as well as the Sample C3 Indicator Connections, Sample Content Connections, and resources still allow for local control, while assisting Supervisory Unions/School Districts with developing vertical and horizontal alignment, supporting literacy, and helping students be more prepared for college and careers.

Framework Structure

The Vermont Framework for K-8 Social Studies supports the teaching of civics, economics, geography, and history within Vermont and supports equity by providing a cohesive and coordinated vision of student-centered learning across Vermont schools. The Framework is grade-banded in alignment with the C3 standards (K-2, 3-5, and 6-8), which provides the foundation for building a progression of learning within each grade band. The framework has been aligned with C3 standard indicators to verify that opportunities for assessment can occur within each band, while not necessarily within each grade. The SU/SD could develop a curriculum sequence based on the framework to determine where and when assessment of C3 standard indicators would take place knowing that not all indicators may be assessed in every grade.

Each grade begins with a curriculum scope, providing clarity of direction for both teacher and student. The scope outlines grade-level skills and content knowledge, assisting teachers to build on prior learning. Each scope also aligns with state-adopted standards, Education Quality Standards (EQS), and multiple other states/districts/national organizations and provides grade-appropriate resources for Vermont educators. For some grades, content may be similar to what has been traditionally taught in Vermont, such as concepts of self, family, and community in the early grades, or Vermont History, which is most often taught in grade four (Vermont History Museum). In others, content may be considered more novel for a particular grade level in Vermont. The curriculum guidance provided in multiple states (see acknowledgments below) was researched to specifically identify universal social studies content and expectations in grades K-8 and to ensure that this Vermont Framework would honor the diversity of both culture and perspective in the U.S. and world. The inquiry process and transferable skills were incorporated in the framework as appropriate. To support educators bringing varied levels of expertise in civics, economics, geography, and history, each grade-level document includes Sample C3 Indicator Connections, Sample Content Connections, and suggested resources.

The AOE-selected Sample C3 Indicators are based on national standards, research, and input from the field. How the C3 indicators within each grade band will be formally assessed is left to SU/SD discretion, with the understanding that all standards have a place in the curriculum and in student learning.

- The Inquiry Process Sample C3 Indicators have been identified from C3 indicators Dimensions 1-4 for educators to incorporate student questioning, source evaluation, and argumentation within the K-2, 3-5, and 6-8 grade bands.
- C3 Dimension 2 (civics, economics, geography, history) indicators are represented within each grade band and the opportunities for learning and assessment within each Sample C3 Indicator are detailed in each grade as appropriate. For example, within Civics, there are opportunities for learning and assessment of the Sample C3 Indicators for Participation and Deliberation in grades K, 1, and 2, while in History, the Perspectives Indicators would be most authentically assessed in Grades 1 and 2 only.
- Sample C3 Indicator Connections offer suggestions for learning targets or can be used as "Students Will Be Able To (SWBAT)" opportunities; they provide transparency for students/parents/guardians in regard to learning expectations.
- Sample Content Connections are aligned to C3 Sample Indicators and provide educators with overarching concepts, critical knowledge examples, vocabulary, and considerations for building lessons/units. It is important to acknowledge that some content spirals K-12, allowing for increased levels of critical thinking, evidence evaluation, and argumentation. We recognize that these are just a sample of the various ways in which to teach these concepts and skills.
- Sample resources from local and national organizations are provided. Formative and summative assessment resources are included.

Guiding Principles for Effective History and Social Science Education

The Vermont Agency of Education strives to prepare students for college and career readiness while developing knowledgeable, critical thinking, and actively involved members of our democratic society. The following principles (abridged from the Massachusetts Curriculum Framework for History and Social Science) can guide implementation of the framework in Vermont:

Guiding Principle 1: An effective history and social science education teaches students about the legacy of democratic government.

Study of history and social science prepares students to understand their rights and responsibilities as informed residents and citizens of a democratic society and to appreciate the shared values of this country. To become informed citizens, students need to acquire knowledge and experience of:

- the principles and philosophy of government in the founding documents of the United States;
- the structure and purposes of democratic government in the United States at the national, state, and local level;
- the structure and purposes of types of government other than democracy;

- how the concepts of liberty, equality, justice, and human and civil rights shape the United States;
- the achievements of democratic government and the challenges to maintaining it;
- ways to act as a citizen to influence government within the democratic system; and
- the importance of respectful public discourse and dissent in a democracy.

Guiding Principle 2: An effective history and social science education incorporates diverse perspectives and acknowledges that perceptions of events are affected by race, ethnicity, culture, religion, education, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, and personal experience.

The traditional motto of the United States is “E pluribus unum” – out of many, one. A history and social science education that does justice to the remarkable diversity of our country must tell the histories of individuals and groups and honor a plurality of life stories while acknowledging our ongoing struggle to achieve a more perfect union. Teaching how the concepts of freedom, equality, the rule of law, and human rights have influenced United States and world history necessarily involves discussions of race, ethnicity, culture, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, and other characteristics. Effective instruction challenges students to value their own heritage while embracing our common ideals and shared experiences as they develop their own rigorous thinking about accounts of events. Effective instruction celebrates the progress the United States has made in embracing diversity, while at the same time encouraging honest and informed academic discussions about prejudice, racism, and bigotry in the past and present.

Guiding Principle 3: Every student deserves to study history and social science every year, from pre-kindergarten through grade 12.

Like learning to read, write, or perform well in any other subject, learning history and social science takes time. An effective history and social science education is given adequate time in the school day to build knowledge and skills of increasing complexity.

Guiding Principle 4: An effective history and social science education teaches students to think historically.

This framework presents a broad scope of time and place with the intent of helping students understand that their lives are connected to the long sweep of history. In the elementary grades, students become acquainted with the concepts of chronology, cause-and-effect relationships, and the role chance plays in historical events. In middle school, students learn that complex events have both intended and unintended consequences. By examining primary and secondary sources, students develop an appreciation for the importance of historical context and point of view. They learn that participants in historical events can often hold vastly different ideas about how those

events unfolded. Because historians of different generations can have different perceptions, it is important that readings include a variety of opinions and historical interpretations.

Guiding Principle 5: An effective history and social science education integrates knowledge from many fields of study.

The fields of history, geography, civics, and economics form the core of a history and social science education. This framework is designed to include a breadth of knowledge, not as isolated facts to be simply memorized, but as useable knowledge to be integrated into an understanding of the world.

Guiding Principle 6: An effective history and social science education builds students' capacities for research, reasoning, making logical arguments, and thinking for themselves.

In an effective history and social science education, students engage in inquiry, reading, research, discussion, writing, and making presentations – these activities link the history and social science disciplines to English language arts and literacy. In the course of applying these practices, students learn how to evaluate texts for bias intended to influence their opinions, and about the patterns of thought and reasoning of historians, geographers, political scientists, and economists. They learn to raise and refine questions and organize arguments and explanations by using structures such as comparison and contrast, cause and effect, or problem and solution. They learn to apply different forms of analysis, including contextually rich reading, visual analysis, spatial/geographical analysis, or quantitative reasoning.

Guiding Principle 7: An effective history and social science education improves reading comprehension by increasing students' content knowledge.

A rich education in history and social science involves extensive reading of challenging grade-level texts, which not only contributes to the development of basic reading skills but also introduces students to concepts and academic language that ultimately improve reading comprehension. Researcher Daniel Willingham contends, "Teaching content is teaching reading." Content knowledge improves reading comprehension because it enables a student to make connections about events and ideas across texts.

Guiding Principle 8: An effective history and social science education incorporates the study of current events and news/media literacy.

When teaching history and social science, teachers have a unique responsibility to help students consider events – including current events – in a broad historical, geographical, social, or economic context. This framework helps students learn to

evaluate information, question and verify its source, distinguish fact from inference, and reasoned judgment supported by evidence from varying degrees of bias.

Guiding Principle 9: An effective history and social science education teaches students about using data analysis and digital tools as research and presentation techniques in the social sciences.

History and social science teachers have a long history of teaching students to read, interpret, and create graphs, charts, maps, timelines, and illustrations. New opportunities for answering questions with data are available in the ever-expanding supply of online databases.

Guiding Principle 10: An effective history and social science education develops social and emotional skills.

Social and emotional learning has demonstrated an increase in academic achievement and communication skills, improved attitudes and behaviors, and developed empathy. These skills are also practical civic skills that students need to engage effectively with others in the public problem-solving of civic and democratic life. Teachers support the development of these skills by:

- helping students understand how their own unique experiences and ideas influence their perceptions of and feelings about history and current situations (self-awareness);
- encouraging students' own power to take thoughtful action (self-management);
- increasing students' understanding of others' fundamental needs and human and civil rights (social awareness);
- increasing students' capacity to participate in dialogue across differences and to take on the perspectives of others whose experience and position in the world differs from their own (dialogue and perspective-taking);
- encouraging students to collaborate respectfully with diverse peers (relationship skills);
- providing opportunities for students to define and make informed choices when participating in democratic practices (responsible decision-making); and
- creating opportunities for students to work together on projects that aim to promote a public good beyond the classroom, in the school, or in the larger community (civic action).

(Abridged from Massachusetts Curriculum Framework for History and Social Science, pp. 13-16.)

The Scope and Sequence for Grades K-8

Kindergarten – Me and My Community

Grade 1 – People, Places, and the Environment

Grade 2 – The Americas

Grade 3 – Global Interactions

Grade 4 – Vermont, the Early Republic, and the U.S.: Pre-Colonial Times through the Civil War

Grade 5 – World Geography and Ancient Civilizations I: Western Asia, the Middle East, North Africa, Sub-Saharan Africa

Grade 6 – World Geography and Ancient Civilization II: South and East Asia, Oceania, Europe

Grade 7 – Vermont and the U.S.: Reconstruction to the Modern Civil Rights Movement

Grade 8 – Civics and Economics in Action

Acknowledgments

The following national/state/district-level documents have been utilized to create this document (note other organizations have been referenced throughout each grade-level document, as necessary):

2021 Minnesota K-12 Academic Standards in Social Studies

2024 Oregon Social Science Standards

Colorado Social Studies Academic Standards

Connecticut Elementary and Secondary Social Studies Frameworks

Kentucky Academic Standards for Social Studies

Massachusetts Curriculum Framework for History and Social Science

National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) Civics Framework

New Jersey Learning Standards - Social Studies

New York Learning Standards for Social Studies

North Carolina Standard Course of Study

Vermont Early Learning Standards